

Data Day 2027 Champions: What Makes a Strong Keynote

The event and the theme

Data Day 2027 is Thursday, February 18, 2027, at the Center for Workforce Development at Columbus State Community College: our fifth annual gathering of Central Ohio's data community, with 200+ attendees, two keynotes, and 16 breakout sessions.

The theme is **Plotting What's Next**, *five years forward for Central Ohio's data community*. After five years of gathering the data, we can see the trend line, and now we plot the course ahead. The keynotes carry that thread: a **forward-looking morning opener** and a **lunch "what's next" session**. Both look ahead rather than back.

What makes a strong Data Day keynote

The best keynotes speak to the whole room, practitioners and leaders alike.

Forward-looking. Speaks to where public-sector data use and analysis are heading. A look ahead, not a retrospective.

Relevant to the region. Resonates with Central Ohio's public sector. National perspective is welcome when it lands locally.

Draws a crowd. A compelling voice attendees will make time for. Someone whose perspective sets the tone for the day.

Engaging and accessible. Substance that lands across skill levels, with room for the Q&A and discussion Data Day is known for.

A candidate does not need to hit all four. Two strong ones and a real connection to the region usually make a name worth surfacing.

Less good fits: sales presentations or product demos (vendors are welcome when the talk is about the work, not the product), purely technical deep dives (point those people to the Call for Proposals), and retrospectives on the past five years.

How to suggest someone

Use the **suggestion form**. It takes about three minutes and asks for a name, their organization, why they would be a great fit, and whether you have a personal connection.

Timing: suggestions are most useful by **late September 2026**. The form closes **October 31**, and keynotes are finalized in **mid-November**.

If you know them, say so on the form. We will send you an introduction template, and you make the connection once you have checked that they are open to it. You never have to cold-email anyone.

Where your role ends

You scout and connect. **MORPC staff handle the invitation, the vetting, and any negotiation.**

Please do not discuss honoraria, travel, or commitments, and do not announce a speaker before we have released it. If a candidate asks about terms, hand them to staff.

Questions? Jordan Inskeep, jinskeep@morpc.org